

CREATING TENSION

Making the reader feel on edge



1 What is it?

Creating Tension

Creating tension means making the reader feel **uneasy, alert, or on edge** — usually because something might be about to go wrong.

a threat + uncertainty = tension

2 See it in action

Short, sharp sentences

A creak. Then silence. Then footsteps.

Withheld information

She knew someone was in the house — she just didn't know where.

A ticking clock

They had exactly ten minutes before the doors sealed shut.

Body language

His hand hovered over the phone, unsure whether to make the call.



Mfalme says...

Look for **short sentences and paragraph breaks** — writers often shorten their sentences specifically to build tension in a scene.

FUN FACT

Filmmakers call withholding information from the audience while a character is in danger "dramatic irony in reverse" — in prose, writers use the exact same trick just with sentence structure instead of a camera.

3 Why writers use it

Creating Tension helps writers: keep a reader emotionally invested and reading on, create a physical sense of unease through pace and sentence structure, and build toward a release (a reveal, an escape, a resolution) that feels earned.

Tension often relies on what the writer DOESN'T say — withholding a key piece of information from the reader is one of the most reliable ways to keep them anxiously reading on.

4 Don't mix it up!

Tension

- A feeling of **unease NOW**
- Built moment-to-moment
- Can happen without any real danger

Suspense

- Anticipation about the **future**
- Built over a longer stretch
- Usually involves a specific unknown outcome



Watch out!

Tension isn't only created by dramatic events — silence, short sentences, and a character's hesitation can build just as much unease as an explicit threat.



Look here!

Ask what information the writer is **deliberately withholding** from you — not knowing something is often what makes a scene tense.

5 Quick recap

Makes the reader feel
uneasy

Built through pace and
withheld info

Often uses short, sharp
sentences



You got this!

Try writing three short sentences describing someone waiting for bad news — use silence and small physical details rather than stating "she felt anxious."